

→ Debatable.

08.00 'that a false theory would explain, in so satisfactory a manner as does the theory of natural selection, the several large classes of fact above specified.'

10.00 • Q) How do we decide which of the competing hypotheses provides the 'best explanation' of the data? What criteria determine this?

12.00 • Popular answer — A good explanation should be simple, or parsimonious.

14.00 • Consider again the cheese-in-the-larder example. There are two pieces of data that need explaining: the missing cheese and the scratching noises. The mouse hypothesis postulates just one cause — a mouse — to explain both pieces of data. But the maid-and-boiler hypothesis must postulate two causes — a dishonest maid and an overheating boiler to explain the same data. So the mouse hypothesis is more parsimonious, hence better.

16.00 • The Darwin example is similar. Darwin's theory could explain a diverse range of facts about the living world, not just anatomical similarities between species. Each of these facts could in principle be explained in other ways, but the theory of evolution explained all the facts in one go — that is what made it the best explanation of the data.

18.00 Imp
• Q) Do we have reason to think that the universe is simple rather than complex? Preferring a theory which explains the data in terms of the fewest number of causes seem sensible. But are there any objective grounds to think that such a theory is more likely to be true than a less simple rival? Or is simplicity something scientists value because it makes their theories easier to formulate and to understand?

March 2024							April 2024						
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